



Figure 1: Microsoft Windows, an oft-perceived thorn in the side of open source proponents

connect to AIM, Google Talk, ICQ, IRC, XMPP and other networks concurrently.

Email client

Thunderbird: Developed by Mozilla in 2004, Thunderbird is still one of the most popular open source software challenging Microsoft Outlook today. It caters to the growing demand for an email client for modern users.

Productivity and utilities software

LibreOffice: A powerful office suite, LibreOffice provides an uncluttered and intuitive user interface that serves to boost productivity. The software kit includes several applications that make it one of the friendliest and fastest-growing office suites in the free and open source community.

PuTTY: This is a free implementation of SSH and Telnet for Windows and UNIX platforms, along with an *xterm* terminal emulator. It is written and maintained primarily by Simon Tatham.

7zip: This is a free and open source file-archiver—a software used to put groups of files into compressed folders termed as ‘archives’. Written by Igor Pavlov in 1999, it has a high compression ratio, making it a very effective software.

File sharing software

FileZilla: Born as a class project of three students in 2001, this tame software has since evolved into a gigantic full-featured file manager and file server. FileZilla offers protected file sharing, which requires a user name and password to access the shared data.

DC++: Technological progress has given us the direct connect (DC) protocol used for sharing files over the Internet. The open source DC++ is the most popular peer-to-peer file sharing client based on the direct connect protocol.

Media players

VLC media player: VLC is widely used as a media player and streaming software. It is capable of playing files, discs, Web cams, devices and streams. It can even be used as a video downloader.

Audacity: A free and open source audio editor and recorder, Audacity allows users to record live audio, convert



Figure 2: Open source Web browsers and other tools



Figure 3: Communication and file sharing utilities for developers



Figure 4: Hypervisor and media-based software for Windows

records and tapes to digital formats, or mix pre-built digital audio tracks.

GIMP: The brainchild of Spencer Kimball and Peter Mattis, the GNU Image Manipulation Program or GIMP serves as an open source graphics editor, an alternative to Adobe Photoshop. It can be used to create and update photos or clip-art in various image formats such as JPEG, PNG, TIFF, and so on.

Hypervisors and emulators

VirtualBox: VirtualBox is professional grade, open source virtualisation software. It is a general-purpose full virtualiser for x86 hardware, targeted at server, desktop and embedded use.

Cygwin: This is a large collection of GNU and open source tools that provide functionality similar to a Linux distribution on Windows. Cygwin provides native integration of Windows-based applications, data, and other system resources with applications, software tools and data of the UNIX-like environment. 

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